

“**Teach your daughters** how to **wail**; **teach** one another a **lament** ... **Death** has **climbed in** through our **windows**.
”

HEBREW BIBLE, JEREMIAH 9:21

EXPERIENCES OF DEATH

Loss and grief

While death is a common thread that links us all, the customs and beliefs surrounding death differ greatly from culture to culture across time. Women, particularly widows, have long played a significant role in burying and mourning their loved ones.

DEATH HAS BEEN personified as a woman in many cultures throughout history. Mexican folk saint Santa Muerte—a skeletal woman not unlike the male personification of the Grim Reaper in medieval Europe—is one such figure, and an Arabic proverb from the Maghreb in Africa declares that death is a woman by the name of Moûny. Various cultures worshipped death goddesses—Haiti’s Voodoo Maman Brigitte among them—or had mythological queens of the underworld, such as the Mesopotamian Ereshkigal. In

Women even died in funerary rites, in order to follow dead husbands or masters into the afterlife. One well-known example is the now illegal practice of *sati*, once common in the Hindu community in India, in which a widow immolated herself on her husband’s funeral pyre.

“[The] **wailing** and laceration of women in **mourning**, like a **wave** of the **sea**, go on **unceasingly**.
”

MĀORI PROVERB



◀ Adorned for death

This female mummy (c. 200 BCE) is from the Paracas Necropolis in Peru. This woman was buried with textiles, gold, and bone jewelry, indicating that she was royal.